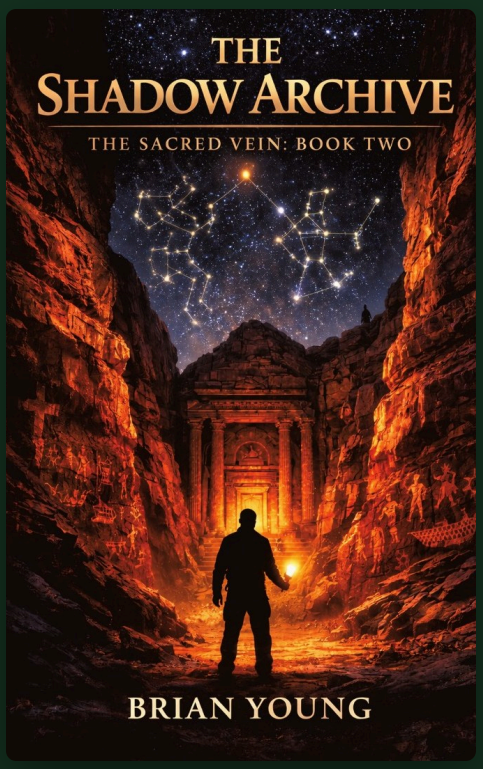
BOOK CLUB KIT

The Shadow Archive



A NOVEL BY BRIAN YOUNG

A reading plan, a who's who, discussion questions for all three Parts, themes, a map of the story, what the novel draws on, and a letter from the author

AUTHOR
Brian Young

SERIES
Book Two of the Sacred Vein series

SETTING
Present day: the Utah reservation and canyon country, Denver, San Antonio and Austin, Germany's Black Forest, Rome, and the Nevada desert

FORMAT
Novel, prologue, three Parts, 33 chapters, epilogue

GOOD FOR
Adult book clubs, library reading groups, readers who finished Book One

Free to print and share with your club.

BRIANYOUNGAUTHOR.COM · HELLO@BRIANYOUNGAUTHOR.COM

Hello Again, Book Club

Hi again. I'm Brian. If your club is reading this, you probably already spent one book with Ammon, Aspen, and Jonas in the Uintas, and you came back for another. Thank you. That still surprises me.

This is Book Two. It leaves the mountains for an attic in Denver, a German church in San Antonio, a guesthouse in the Black Forest, and a canyon in southern Utah. Along the way it picks up a cryptolinguist who drinks her coffee cold, a priest who works in an archive that isn't on any map, and an Oxford archaeologist with a very famous father.

Book One asked who owns the past. This one asks who gets to decide what the rest of us are ready to know. Nearly everyone in it has a confident answer. I don't.

The book is for my kids, Kaylie, Owen, and Kara. The dedication says the real treasure was never hidden in a chamber. That part isn't fiction.

If your group lands somewhere interesting, write to me at hello@brianyoungauthor.com. I read everything.

Brian

The book in a minute (no spoilers)

At the end of *The Sacred Vein*, Ammon Lundquist found Carre-Shinob and chose to protect it. Now the chamber's codices are being translated at the tribal cultural center under a fragile partnership between the guardians and a team of scholars, and the hunt is supposed to be over. Then a guardian codex turns up one last entry by Ammon's ancestor, F.W.C. Hathenbruck, and his great-grandmother's locket turns out to hold one more message. Hathenbruck kept secrets even from the people he trusted most, and the biggest of them has a name: the First Temple.

The trail runs from an aunt's attic in Denver to a German church in San Antonio, a medical library in Austin, and a house in the Black Forest. Ammon, Aspen, and Jonas are joined by Yuki Tanaka, a Stanford cryptolinguist with no patience for protocols. They are not alone. What is left of the Consortium is hunting, a quiet office in the Vatican is watching, and an Oxford archaeologist named Margaux Vance, whose father is in federal prison, would very much like to help.

For discussion leaders: the whole story

Spoilers, including the ending. For whoever is leading the discussion.

Part One: The Discovery (Prologue and Chapters 1 to 10)

Dr. Chen's translation of a guardian codex turns up a last entry by Hathenbruck about instructions hidden with his wife, Anna. In Denver, Ammon's estranged great-aunt Clara hands over Anna's locket; its note leads to a hollow bristlecone and a buried brass box holding the shadow archive, twenty years of Hathenbruck's secret copies. Six months later, pages hidden in a false cover name "the First

Temple," and Hathenbruck's testimony confesses, "I copy." A 1926 letter in Clara's attic mentions two gifts, and behind a carved altar panel at St. Johannes Lutheran in San Antonio, Ammon finds a coded page: "The physician's library holds the key." In prison, Elias Vance recruits his daughter Margaux; Jonas's old hacker contact Phantom warns of two buyers; in Austin, Tanaka finds marginalia naming Asklepios and Orion, and Viktor confronts the team. Margaux emails an offer to collaborate; in Rome, Father Tomás sends Konstantin, who privately decides the temple "would stay buried."

Part Two: The Hunt (Chapters 11 to 24)

Over Thomas's and Aspen's objections, Ammon gives Margaux supervised access, and she photographs the translation room at night. Tanaka cracks the cipher: a temple some seven thousand years old, built by people who crossed the ocean, with warnings that "knowledge is fire." Jeremiah, at Englewood, names Viktor Semenov and warns that Margaux may be an inside asset. Too late: she knocks out a guard and empties secure storage, and Viktor's armored SUVs hit the center while Aspen outdrives them. At Clara's house, Tanaka and Jonas fix the star alignment to a canyon in Grand Staircase-Escalante, and Margarethe's letters and Marcus's notes send Ammon and Jonas to the Hoffmann guesthouse near Freiburg, where a four-cylinder lock yields Hathenbruck's map. Konstantin corners them, but Jonas has already sent Aspen a photo of the map. At 3:07 a.m., Viktor's men take Aspen and Tanaka; Clara escapes. Ammon turns to FBI Agent Diana Reyes, makes a deal with Tomás, and gets Jeremiah out to help.

Part Three: The Choice (Chapters 25 to 33 and Epilogue)

At an abandoned uranium mine in Nevada, an FBI raid with four of Tomás's men breaks Viktor's hold. Aspen cuts free and gets Tanaka out, Jeremiah leads Ammon to Vance's hidden files, and Aspen tackles Viktor. Margaux surrenders: "I'm not my father." In the canyon, Thomas and Robert chant open the PORTA VERITATIS at the solstice sunset, and three tests (the last one sung by Aspen) open an archive of bronze tablets, a vast astronomical device, and the history of the "net-weavers," including the weapons they turned on each other. Konstantin, who slipped in behind them, has wired the temple. Tomás stands in his way, Jeremiah tackles him, and the group escapes with about forty tablets and two hundred photographs as the mountain comes down. Konstantin slips his restraints and vanishes. A framework gives the tribe a veto; Jeremiah gets time served, Margaux five years, Viktor life. At the Uinta clearing where Hathenbruck met Kwiyaghat, Ammon is accepted as a guardian, and Aspen tells him they are pregnant. A year later, with baby Anna on Aspen's back, Tanaka locates the Temple of the Southern Stars in Patagonia.

Who's Who

In order of appearance. Aspen uses they/them pronouns, as the novel does.

NAME	WHO THEY ARE, AND WHAT THEY DO IN THE STORY
Ammon Lundquist ***(returning)***	Historian and Hathenbruck's great-great-grandson. Follows his ancestor's last trail, trusts the wrong person once, and has to live with it.
Thomas Wopsock ***(returning)***	Guardian elder, still carrying his wounds from Book One. Opens the temple door with words his grandfather made him memorize at seven.

NAME	WHO THEY ARE, AND WHAT THEY DO IN THE STORY
Aspen Rhoades ***(returning)***	Former ranger, now the guardians' security lead and Ammon's partner. The driver, the fighter, and the first to distrust Margaux.
Clara Lundquist ***(new)***	Ammon's great-aunt in Denver, silent since his father's funeral. Keeps the locket, the letters, and a basement escape route.
Robert Colorow ***(returning)***	Guardian elder whose stories reach back to Walkara. Learns how much Hathenbruck kept from the guardians.
Jonas West ***(returning)***	Reformed hacker, now uneasily famous. Hears from his old crew, gets the map out from under Konstantin, and falls for Tanaka.
Dr. Yuki Tanaka ***(new)***	Stanford cryptolinguist, brilliant and impatient. Breaks the marginalia cipher, finds the canyon in the stars, and survives captivity.
Margaux Vance ***(new)***	Oxford archaeologist and daughter of the imprisoned Elias Vance. Joins the project under supervision and spends the book deciding whether she is her father.
Viktor Semenov ***(new)***	Former Russian military intelligence turned mercenary, taking Elias's calls. Threatens politely, then stops being polite.
Father Tomás Adão ***(new)***	Jesuit who has spent thirty years in a hidden Vatican archive managing "inconvenient truths." Sends Konstantin, then starts to doubt.
Konstantin ***(new)***	The Church's fixer, thirty years in the work and sure he is protecting the faithful. Trails the team from Freiburg to the canyon.
Jeremiah Stone ***(returning)***	Ammon's old rival, now in federal prison and changed by the chamber. Trades what he knows for a chance to prove it.
Gerhard and Elke Hoffmann ***(new)***	Descendants of Anna's sister Margarethe, running a guesthouse near Freiburg. Have guarded a vault under Friedrich's study without ever opening it.
Agent Diana Reyes ***(new)***	FBI special agent in Denver, skeptical and procedural. Agrees to help if everyone plays by her rules.

Pick Your Plan

Most clubs meet once. For two meetings, the natural break is the end of Chapter 18, a little before the halfway point, when the team has gone to ground in Denver and the trail turns toward Germany.

PLAN	READ	WHERE YOU STOP
One meeting	The whole book	Allow 90 minutes. Pick six to ten questions, then finish with "After the last page."

PLAN	READ	WHERE YOU STOP
Two meetings, first	Prologue through Chapter 18	Ammon and Jonas have borrowed passports and a flight to Frankfurt. Use the Part One questions and Part Two questions 1 to 4.
Two meetings, second	Chapter 19 through the Epilogue	The end. Start with Margaux on the plane.

Discussion Questions

Part One: The Discovery (Prologue and Chapters 1 to 10)

1. Clara greets Ammon with “So. You found it. The treasure everyone wasted their lives looking for.” She kept the locket to “protect what was left of this family,” then hands it over. What changed her mind, and was she right to wait so long?

2. Hathenbruck’s hidden testimony comes down to two words: “Ich kopiere.” Robert, who guarded the chamber all his life, says the guardians will decide “whether he was wise or merely afraid.” Which was he?

3. Ammon tells Tanaka “there’s a difference between sharing and dumping,” and she answers with her grandmother’s line: “Fire can warm or burn, depending on how you tend it.” Who should decide how fast the codices reach the world?

4. Margaux tells her father, “I can’t become what you were.” Minutes later he tells Viktor, “Especially family sentimentality.” Did you believe she could stay clear of his methods? When did you stop believing it, if you did?

5. Phantom sold the team’s data to both buyers, then warned Jonas for free: “You found something worth protecting. That’s more than most of us managed.” Does his confession count for anything? How does Jonas’s own past shape how he hears it?

6. Viktor calls his threat outside the library “education,” and Ammon says, “He’s a message, not a weapon.” Why is a polite threat more frightening than a loud one?

7. Chapter 10 ends with late-night calls: Margaux softens and then hardens a text to Viktor, Tomás asks Konstantin for “options,” and Konstantin quietly decides the opposite. Brother Mihail once told him “faith that requires ignorance is not faith.” Whose reasoning did you find most human, and whose most dangerous?

> *Good people can still cause harm when they feel cornered.*
> THOMAS WOPSOCK, CHAPTER 3

Part Two: The Hunt (Chapters 11 to 24)

1. Ammon argues for letting Margaux in: “If we reject everyone who might pose a risk, we’ll be working alone.” Aspen says no, and Thomas warns that “The Consortium planned in generations.” Was Ammon wrong, or unlucky? What would you have done?
2. The decoded codex says the builders hid the temple because “the world was not ready.” Thomas concludes, “We’re not the originators. We’re inheritors.” How does learning that their duty is thousands of years older change what the guardians owe?
3. At the council, Thomas tells Ammon, “You wanted so badly to believe in partnership that you forgot our enemies wear many faces.” Ammon answers, “I was wrong.” Is that enough? What should accountability look like for a well-meant mistake?
4. Tanaka’s grandmother spent her life rebuilding a heritage someone tried to erase, and Tanaka says anyone who buries knowledge is “stealing pieces of humanity’s inheritance.” Is she also describing the guardians? Where does protection end and suppression begin?
5. On the plane, Margaux reads the plan to take Aspen and Tanaka, drafts a warning, deletes it, and types “Understood. Standing by.” Why doesn’t she send it? Is this the moment she becomes her father, or is there still a way back?
6. In Freiburg, Konstantin says, “We are shepherds,” charged with protecting the flock “from knowledge that would harm them.” Afterward, Ammon admits he wonders “if any of us really knows what we’re doing.” Is that doubt a weakness, or what separates him from Konstantin?
7. To save Aspen, Ammon brings in the FBI, the priest who sent Konstantin, and Jeremiah. “I’m asking you to distrust me less than you distrust the alternative,” he tells Tomás. Was the alliance smart, desperate, or both?

> *A man who knows he’s doing wrong can be reasoned with. A man who believes he’s righteous? He’ll do anything.*
>
> AMMON LUNDQUIST, CHAPTER 21

Part Three: The Choice (Chapters 25 to 33 and Epilogue)

1. Margaux walks toward the FBI with her hands raised: “I’m not my father. I won’t die for his dream.” Ammon says, “That’s not redemption,” and she answers, “But it’s a start.” Is five years the right sentence? How does her path compare with Jeremiah’s?
2. The temple opens only for visitors who pass three tests, physical, intellectual, and spiritual, and Aspen passes the last by singing a song their grandmother sang. Why would builders who prized knowledge make the final test something you can’t study for?
3. Tanaka calls the archive “an arsenal,” and the inscription says “The difference lies not in the knowledge itself but in the hearts of those who wield it.” Do you agree, or are some kinds of knowledge dangerous no matter who holds them?

4. Facing Konstantin's dead man's switch, Tomás admits, "I told myself it was faith, but it was control." Konstantin calls him "a tool." Which of them better represents the institution they serve? Can an institution change if the people inside it do?

5. Ammon chases Konstantin alone and loses him. "Some people can't be saved," he thinks. Jeremiah chose redemption; Konstantin chose escape. What separates them, and could either man have chosen otherwise?

6. At the command post, Robert says, "We've heard pretty words before," and Ammon answers, "Then don't trust words. Trust structure." Is the framework they build (tribal veto, guardian custody, co-authorship) a real answer to five hundred years of broken promises?

7. At the ceremony, Ammon says the sacred vein "isn't about gold, and it isn't about blood. It's about responsibility." Minutes later Aspen tells him it is "going to have another link." Does the pregnancy fit his idea, or pull the book back toward bloodlines?

After the last page

1. Line up everyone who claims to know what the world is ready for: Hathenbruck, the builders, the guardians, Tomás, Konstantin, Margaux, Tanaka, and Reyes's government. Ammon says "waiting for perfection is just another way of saying never." Who comes closest to right?

2. Book One ended with a discovery the guardians could protect. Book Two ends with a temple destroyed and forty tablets saved. "Not gone," Aspen says. "Buried. There's a difference." Is there? Was the loss the real subject of this book?

3. Elias and Margaux, Hathenbruck and the descendants he tested, Clara and the family she hid from, Ammon and Aspen and Anna. What do parents owe the children who inherit their obsessions, and what do the children owe back?

4. The novel borrows real places and institutions, from San Antonio's King William district and Freiburg's cathedral to the Vatican and the FBI. Where did you want to stop and look something up? Does a thriller that invents a secret Vatican office owe its readers anything?

5. Ammon trusts Margaux and is burned; he trusts Jeremiah and is rewarded. "Everyone deserves that chance," he tells Margaux in Chapter 11. Is his trust a strength, a weakness, or both? How would the book change if Aspen had won the argument?

6. The dedication ends, "Seek wisely. Protect fiercely. Love completely." Which of the three is hardest for you, and which character lives it best?

Themes

Knowledge is fire

"Knowledge is fire. It can warm a house or burn it down." The temple's last inscription echoes the codex Tanaka decodes in Chapter 12 and the grandmother she quotes in Chapter 3. The image never settles the question. Fire doesn't choose; the people tending it do.

Who decides we're ready

Hathenbruck wrote that "the world was not ready to receive it," and hid what he found from everyone. The builders sealed, Tomás managed, Konstantin buries, Margaux steals in the name of sharing. Ammon's reply: "waiting for perfection is just another way of saying never."

Guardians, not judges

"We are guardians, not judges," Margarethe tells her son when he wants to open the box. Gerhard, Clara, and the guardian families all keep things they may never see. The book asks what that kind of faithfulness is worth, and what it costs.

What children inherit

"She was afraid of becoming him." Margaux's whole story is in that line. Aspen says their family "passed down meaning," Clara calls the legacy "A responsibility," and the book ends with a daughter named for a woman who kept a secret in a locket.

Trust, given and broken

"Trust builds slow," Thomas warns in Chapter 3. Ammon gives it fast and pays for it. By the end he wants trust built into rules: "Then don't trust words. Trust structure." Watching Margaux sentenced, he concludes that "trust was a gift that could be weaponized."

Mercy, and those who refuse it

Jeremiah says he "stood in a place where mercy was built into the walls," and the book takes him at his word. Konstantin is offered the same chances and walks into the desert. Tomás lands in between. Ammon's verdict on the rest: "Some people don't want to be."

What the Novel Draws On

The Shadow Archive is fiction, and its copyright page says so. Its About the Author page says the series grows out of "years of research into the real history of the Lost Rhoades Mine." The Author's Note is a thank-you to readers with no historical claims, so what follows is what the story itself says. Treat the First Temple, the net-weavers, the codices, Hathenbruck's papers, and the Vatican's secret office as invention, and check the rest before repeating it.

Hathenbruck's two countries. As the novel tells it, Friedrich left Freiburg in 1868, worked among German immigrants in San Antonio, and went home in 1891 to build a vault. Ammon reads that German immigration to Texas "had been one of the largest in American history." The church, books, vault, and letters are story devices.

The sky. Tanaka explains that the healer Asklepios is linked to the constellation Ophiuchus, the serpent-bearer, which "isn't part of the standard zodiac," and that precession shifts the stars over centuries, so she has to work backward to the sky Hathenbruck saw. The solstice alignment, the light-keyed doors, and the temple's date are invention.

Grand Staircase-Escalante. The novel describes the monument as 1.9 million acres of slot canyons and rock art in southern Utah, and puts the First Temple in an unnamed canyon inside it.

Contact across the oceans. Margaux's field, pre-Columbian trans-oceanic contact, is described as "A field full of cranks, but also of real questions mainstream archaeology wouldn't touch." The net-weavers, the twelve temples, and the weapons tablets are fiction.

The Church and its archives. Tomás's shelves hold "The Galileo files," and he reflects on the centuries it took the Church to rehabilitate Galileo. The hidden wing, the "quieter offices," Konstantin, and the priest who visited Freiburg in the 1970s are invention.

> WANT TO DIG DEEPER? FIVE TOPICS TO LOOK UP
>
> The constellation Ophiuchus and the precession of the equinoxes · Grand Staircase-Escalante National Monument · German immigration to Texas · Theories of pre-Columbian transoceanic contact · The Galileo affair

Map of the Story

PLACE	WHAT HAPPENS THERE
The tribal cultural center, on the reservation	The codex (Prologue); the testimony (Ch. 4); Margaux at night (Ch. 11); the assault (Ch. 14); the rebuilt center (Epilogue)
Clara's house, Denver, and the hollow tree	The locket (Ch. 1); the shadow archive (Ch. 2); the safe house (Ch. 16 to 18); the raid (Ch. 22)
Englewood federal prison, Colorado	Elias recruits Margaux (Ch. 6); Jeremiah talks (Ch. 13, 24)
San Antonio and Austin, Texas	The altar panel (Ch. 7); the marginalia, and Viktor (Ch. 9)
The Vatican archive, Rome	Tomás calls Konstantin (Ch. 10); Pietro's challenge (Ch. 15)
Gasthaus Hoffmann, Freiburg	The vault (Ch. 20); Konstantin in the street (Ch. 21)
An abandoned uranium mine, Nevada	Captivity, the raid, and Margaux's surrender (Ch. 22, 24, 25)
PORTA VERITATIS, Grand Staircase-Escalante	The tests, the archive, and the collapse (Ch. 26 to 30)
A clearing in the Uintas	Ammon joins the guardians; Aspen's news (Ch. 33)

The trail Hathenbruck left, as the novel dates it

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED, IN THE BOOK
1868	Friedrich leaves for America, the riddle's "year of departure" (Ch. 20)
1889	His codex testimony; the San Antonio altar (Ch. 4, 7)
1891	Books donated in Texas; the Freiburg vault built (Ch. 9, 20)
1912 to 1926	Margarethe guards the vault; Friedrich writes Anna about two gifts (Ch. 18, 5)
2011	Marcus visits Freiburg, then dies before he can return (Ch. 18, 20)

Reading the Series, and Get the Book

Book One: *The Sacred Vein.* Historian Ammon Lundquist inherits his family's five-generation obsession with Carre-Shinob, the Lost Rhoades Mine, a search that claimed his father's life.

Book Three: *The Hidden Network.* Eighteen months on, the hunt goes global, with dual expeditions, a cave collapse, and a hostage standoff.

Get the book

Paperback and ebook on Amazon (the ebook is in Kindle Unlimited). The paperback can be ordered from any bookstore with the ISBN.

ISBN 978-1-7341794-3-9

brianyoungauthor.com

The whole series, free kits like this one, and news about what comes next.

brianyoungauthor.com

Book club visits

Brian offers free short virtual visits to book clubs and library groups as his schedule allows: a little about how the book came to be, then your questions. Write to hello@brianyoungauthor.com.

A small favor

If your club liked the book, a short review on Amazon or Goodreads is the most useful thing you can do for an independent author. Two sentences about what your group argued over is plenty.

THANK YOU

Thank you for bringing a second book by an independent author to your club. Tell me who your group trusted, and who it didn't: hello@brianyoungauthor.com. I read everything. Brian

The Shadow Archive, copyright 2026 Brian Young. Free to copy for club and library use. Do not alter the cover art.